

SPEECH: Emphatic Stress

Emphatic stress can be defined as the stress or force which is put on a particular word in a sentence for emphasizing that word or a point in the sentence usually only content words (verbs, nouns etc.) are stressed but when attention is being drawn to a particular piece of information, words other than content words such as prepositions, articles, pronouns etc. can be stressed as well. The focus of emphatic stress is exactitude. It is used to convey or show the exact particular meaning the speaker wants the hearer to have or understand. The speaker in his sentence may decide to give or convey a special meaning or message as an answer to someone's question. It is only the particular word he stresses that will help to show, give or convey the special meaning he intends to put across to his hearer.

Emphatic stress enhances the particular meaning the speaker wants to convey and makes the message very clear and easy for the hearer to understand.

Example

1. Musa OPENLY disagreed with his boss yesterday.
 - a. Did Musa secretly disagree with his boss yesterday?
 - b. Did Musa openly disagree with his boss last week?
 - c. Did Ali openly disagree with his boss yesterday
 - d. Did Musa openly agree with his boss yesterday?
2. The DRIVER has taken John away
 - a. Whom did the driver take away?
 - b. Who took John away?
 - c. What did the driver do?
 - d. Where did the driver take John to?

Identify the answers according to the explanation on emphatic stress.

Further exercise

- i. My mother's FRIEND hates pets (not her enemy or any other relation)
 - ii. The manager SACKED the typist (not employee)
 - iii. The PASSENGER boat docked at Calabar (not the cargo boat)
1. John scrubs the floor every SATURDAY
 - a. Does Peter scrub the floor every Saturday?
 - b. Does John scrub the floor every Saturday?
 - c. Does John scrub the wall every Saturday?
 - d. Does John scrub the floor every Sunday?
 2. The officer ACCEPTED the bribe

- a. Did the officer accept a bribe?
 - b. Did the officer accept the gift?
 - c. Did the officer reject the bribe?
 - d. Did the recruit accept the bribe?
3. Ben's wife is always CHARMINE.
- a. Is John's wife always charming?
 - b. Is Ben's sister always charming?
 - c. Is Ben's wife always quarrelsome?
 - d. Is Ben always charming?
4. My mother bakes bread on SUNDAYS.
- a. Does my mother sell bread on Sundays?
 - b. Does my mother sell bread on Sundays?
 - c. Does my mother make biscuits on Saturdays?
 - d. Does my mother make biscuits on Sundays?
5. The CUSTOMER is always right
- a. Is the customer often right?
 - b. Is the customer always wrong?
 - c. When is the customer right?
 - d. Is the seller always right?

Assignment

Choose the one to which the given sentence is the appropriate.

1] MARY loves brown shoes.

A] What colour of shoes does Mary love

B] Does Mary hate brown shoes?

C] Who loves brown shoes ?

D] Does Mary love brown gowns ?

2] It rained ALL day yesterday.

A] For how long did it rain yesterday ?

B] When did it rain all day?

C] Was it dry all day yesterday ?

D] Did it rain all day last week ?

Reference : New Comprehensive English Language for Senior Secondary Schools, by Martins Izuchukwu Amaechi.

Oral English for Schools by Vickky Odozi.